

JAMES LAWSON LIGHTNING · NASHVILLE, TENNESSEE

LONG-TERM ATHLETIC DEVELOPMENT MODEL

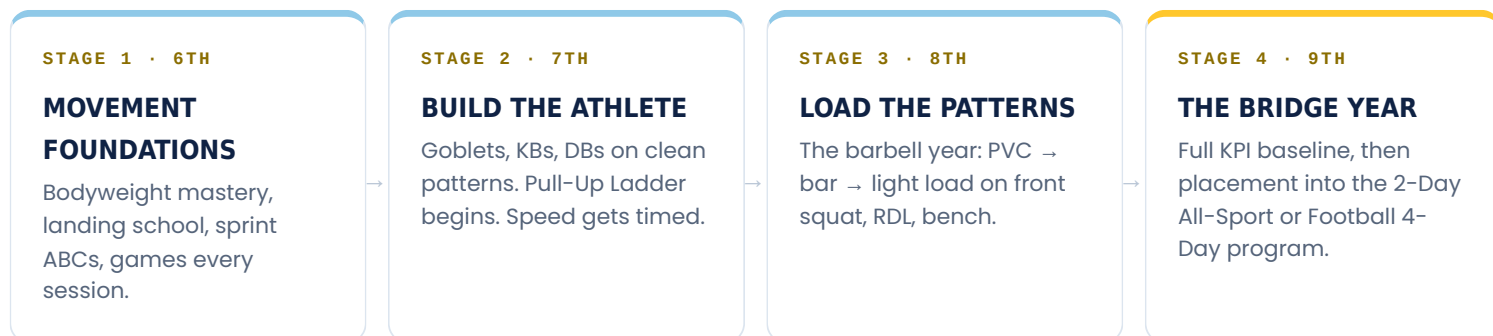
GRADE 6 → FRESHMAN YEAR

SPAN	STAGES	TRAINING	ADVANCEMENT	FEEDS INTO
4 Years	4	2 Days/Wk	Grade + Standards	HS Programs

THE PIPELINE

FOUR STAGES, ONE DESTINATION

Every stage prepares the next. By the time an athlete reaches the high school weight room, the barbell patterns, the Pull-Up Ladder, the warm-up scripts, and the testing language are already theirs.



PRINCIPLES THAT GOVERN EVERY STAGE

TRAIN EVERYTHING, ALWAYS

Every stage sprints, jumps, pushes, pulls, hinges, squats, and braces. The emphasis shifts by age; the menu never shrinks.

MOVEMENT QUALITY BUYS LOAD

Load is never given by grade or birthday — it's purchased with clean reps. Standards from earlier stages never bend as weight goes up.

SPEED IS A SKILL

Sprinting appears in every stage with full recoveries. It's practiced like a skill, never used as punishment or conditioning.

ADVANCE BY GRADE + STANDARDS

Athletes move stages with their grade, and the standards check tells the coach what to regress. A 8th grader missing the hinge standard trains Stage 3 with Stage 2 loading on that pattern.

FUN IS A KPI

Stages 1–2 end every session in competition and games. The best program in the world fails if 6th graders stop showing up.

GROWTH SPURTS ARE NORMAL

During peak growth, coordination temporarily dips. Expect it, say it out loud to athletes and parents, re-teach patterns, and keep loads submaximal until the athlete owns their new limbs.

MOVEMENT FOUNDATIONS

Learn to move, love to train. Own bodyweight positions, land quietly, sprint with intent, and want to come back. External load is limited to med balls and light implements — the barbell can wait, the movement patterns can't. Every session ends in competition because retention is the number-one KPI at this age.

DAY 1 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Game Warm-Up	Tag variations, mirror chase, reaction games — 8 min
B	Jump School	Snap downs, box landings, broad jump to stick — 3x3 each · quiet landings are the standard
C	Sprint ABCs	A-skip, wall drills, falling starts x 10yd — 10 min · full recoveries
D	Bodyweight Strength	Circuit x3: squat to box x8, push-up progression x6-10, dead bug x6/side, plank 20s
E	Compete	Relays, med ball toss for distance, jump contests — 8 min

DAY 2 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Game Warm-Up	Different games than Day 1 — 8 min
B	Med Ball Power	Chest pass + overhead slam — 3x5 each · throw hard, full rest
C	Sprint Mechanics	Build-ups x 15-20yd — 4-6 reps · posture and arm action
D	Pull + Hinge School	Dead hang 15-20s x3, bar rows x8, dowel hinge x8, glute bridge x10
E	Lunge + Trunk	Split squat holds, bear crawl, side plank — circuit x2
F	Compete	Team game finisher — 8 min

GRADUATION STANDARDS — CHECKED AT END OF YEAR

STANDARD	TO GRADUATE, THE ATHLETE CAN...
Squat	Full-depth bodyweight squat x10 — heels down, chest up
Hinge	Dowel hinge with flat back x8 — dowel stays in contact
Push	10 clean push-ups, body in one line
Pull	20-second dead hang + 8 clean bar rows
Land	Stick a low box landing, silent, knees tracking
Sprint	Run 20yd with upright posture and opposite arm-leg action

BUILD THE ATHLETE

Add light load to clean patterns. Patterns earned in Stage 1 now get loaded with goblets, kettlebells, and dumbbells. The Pull-Up Ladder starts here. Speed becomes formal — timed flys enter the testing calendar. Still two games-and-competition touches every week, because they're still kids.

DAY 1 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Warm-Up	WU script + 1 game — 10 min
B	Jump Power	Rotation: low box → broad → hurdle hop (mini) — 3x3 · full rest
C	Goblet Squat	3x8 · light-moderate · depth standard from Stage 1 never bends
D	Push	Push-up progressions → light DB bench — 3x8
E	Row	Chest supported or single-arm DB row — 3x8
F	Trunk + Groin	Circuit x2: Copenhagen intro, dead bug, carry

DAY 2 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Warm-Up	WU script + 1 game — 10 min
B	Acceleration	4–6 x 10–15yd from varied starts · walk-back rest
C	Med Ball Power	Rotational + split-stance throws — 3x3/side
D	KB/DB RDL	3x8 · light · hinge standard holds
E	Pull-Up Ladder	3 sets · by level (most start L0–L1)
F	Single Leg	Split squat or reverse lunge — 3x6/side
G	Compete	Finisher game or relay — 8 min

GRADUATION STANDARDS — CHECKED AT END OF YEAR

STANDARD	TO GRADUATE, THE ATHLETE CAN...
Squat	Goblet squat ~25% bodyweight x8 with Stage 1 depth
Hinge	KB RDL with flat back and hip drive x8
Pull	1 strict pull-up OR 5 clean 4-second eccentrics
Push	DB bench with stable shoulder position x8
Speed	Fly 10 baseline recorded with clean upright posture
Jump	Repeat 3 low hops with stiff, quiet contacts

LOAD THE PATTERNS

The barbell year — earn it slow. Barbell introduction using the exact progression the high school room runs: PVC → empty bar → light load, with Front Rack Levels (R1→R4) governing the front squat. Nobody chases weight — the win is a technically clean bar. Athletes leave this stage ready to test as freshmen.

DAY 1 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Warm-Up	WU script + front-rack micro-dose — 10 min
B	Jump Power	Rotation continues · introduce lateral bound
C	Front Squat (teach)	PVC → empty bar → light — 3x5 · rack by level R1-R3
D	Bench Press (teach)	Empty bar → light — 3x5 · bar path and setup
E	Row	3x8 · heavier than Stage 2, earned by clean reps
F	Trunk + Groin	Circuit x2-3: Copenhagen, side plank + leg lift, carry

DAY 2 · SESSION TEMPLATE		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Warm-Up	WU script — 10 min
B	Speed	Build-ups to short flys — 2-3 reps · timed occasionally
C	Barbell RDL (teach)	PVC → bar → light — 3x5 · same path David and Eli ran
D	Pull-Up Ladder	4 sets · by level · most should reach L1-L2 this year
E	RFESS	3x6/side · light load when clean
F	Med Ball + Carry	Throws 3x3 + loaded carry circuit

GRADUATION STANDARDS — CHECKED AT END OF YEAR

STANDARD	TO GRADUATE, THE ATHLETE CAN...
Front Squat	Empty bar, full depth, rack level R2 or better
Hinge	Barbell RDL with light load, flawless back position
Bench	Empty bar+ with stable bar path and leg drive
Pull	Ladder Level 1 minimum (band-assisted + strict finishers)
Land	Clean stiff landings from low box — repeatable
Speed	Fly 10 trend recorded across the year

THE BRIDGE YEAR

Test, place, and plug into the system. Weeks 1–2: full baseline KPI battery — vertical, broad, fly 10, 5–10–5, mile, plus bench and front squat heavy sets only for athletes who cleared Stage 3 standards. Then athletes plug directly into the existing Lawson programs: multi-sport athletes enter the 2-Day All-Sport Program; football players enter the 4-Day Off-Season on the Foundation track. Varsity track is earned at KPI weeks, never given.

STEP 1 · BASELINE TESTING		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Weeks 1-2	Baseline battery: vertical (3), broad (3), fly 10 (2-3 timed), 5-10-5, mile
B	Weeks 1-2	Bench + front squat clean heavy sets — only if Stage 3 standards are met
C	Placement	FND track by default · VAR requires: vertical ≥ 22" AND front squat ≥ 1.0x BW AND clean landings

STEP 2 · PROGRAM PLACEMENT		
BLOCK	SEGMENT	DETAILS
A	Multi-sport athletes	→ 2-Day All-Sport Program, Week 1
B	Football athletes	→ Football Off-Season 4-Day Program, Week 1, Foundation track
C	Standards gaps	Athletes missing Stage 3 standards run the same programs with ladder/rack-level regressions until cleared

GRADUATION STANDARDS — CHECKED AT END OF YEAR

STANDARD	TO GRADUATE, THE ATHLETE CAN...
Graduation	Full KPI baseline on record and placed in a high school program
Strength	Front squat and RDL loaded with technical mastery
Pull	Ladder Level 2 target (4-7 strict pull-ups)
Speed	Fly 10 + 5-10-5 baselines set
Ownership	Athlete can run their own warm-up script unprompted

WHAT GETS TESTED, AND WHEN

TEST	STAGE 1 · 6TH	STAGE 2 · 7TH	STAGE 3 · 8TH	STAGE 4 · 9TH
Vertical Jump	2x/year	2x/year	3x/year	Full HS calendar
Broad Jump	2x/year	2x/year	3x/year	Full HS calendar
Fly 10	—	Baseline	2-3x/year	Full HS calendar
5-10-5	—	—	Intro / pattern	Baseline + calendar
Mile	—	—	Optional	Baseline · sets tier
Bench / Front Squat 3RM	Never	Never	Never	Only after Stage 3 standards
Movement Standards Check	End of year	End of year	End of year	Entry + KPI weeks

Same standardization rules as the high school system: same surface, same warm-up, same timing method, same attempts — so a 7th grader's fly 10 is comparable to his own junior-year number.

COACHING NON-NEGOTIABLES

- No IRMs before Stage 4 — and no grinders at any stage, ever.
- Every session includes sprinting and jumping, fresh, with full recoveries.
- The standard beats the load. If depth, back position, or landing quality breaks, the weight comes down that day — no negotiation.
- Regress the pattern, not the athlete. A standards gap means one exercise moves back a level, not the whole kid repeating a stage.
- Track everything. Every jump and fly goes in the athlete's record — it becomes their profile the day they enter the high school system.